



USA TRIATHLON EDUCATION

TrainingPeaks Athlete Zone Set Up Guide

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Overview

TrainingPeaks builds all of its workout metrics from the thresholds and zones in your account settings, so setting them correctly is the first job after you sign up. This guide covers both account types: Premium athletes, who can use fully custom zones, and free Basic athletes, who set a threshold and let a built-in zone method do the rest.

The short version:

- **Premium:** enter the zone ranges from your zone calculator as a custom zone method, or have your coach apply a template for you.
- **Basic:** enter your threshold and pick a built-in method. The Joe Friel method is the closest match to a 7-zone system (Zones 1 to 4, then 5a, 5b, 5c).

Either way, set zones per sport. TrainingPeaks does not carry the default zones over to sport-specific workouts.

Before you start: your thresholds

Gather one threshold per measure you train with. LT2 is the anchor in every case, so use the values from your calculator or your latest test.

Sport	What TrainingPeaks needs	LT2 equals
Bike	Power (threshold power) and heart rate	FTP
Run	Speed/Pace and heart rate	Lactate (anaerobic) threshold pace
Swim	Speed/Pace	Critical Swim Speed (CSS)

If you do not set a threshold for a sport and then upload that sport, TrainingPeaks falls back to the default threshold. That skews your metrics, so set each sport before your first uploads. TrainingPeaks defines functional threshold as the maximal effort you can hold for about an hour, and its [athlete guide](#) explains the rest.

If you also want your LT1 zones to match your calculator, keep your calculator's athlete category (Age-Group, Performance, or Elite) in mind, because the LT1 percentage and the Zone 1 to 4 boundaries depend on it.

Premium athletes: set up custom zones

Premium lets you enter your own zone ranges, so your TrainingPeaks zones can match your 7-zone calculator exactly. Do this on the web, since custom zones cannot be created in the mobile app.

1. Log in on the web, click your name, and choose **Settings**, then **Zones**.
2. Pick the type: **Heart Rate**, **Power**, or **Speed/Pace**.
3. Under **Add Activity**, add the sport (Bike, Run, or Swim). Do not rely on the default zones, because they do not carry over to sport-specific workouts.
4. Enter your threshold, then choose a zone method with the same number of zones you need. Use **Add Zone** if you need more.
5. Rename the zones and enter the range for each one from your calculator output.
6. Click **Save**.

Do not overlap zones. Start each zone at the next whole number. If your calculator shows Zone 4 ending at 100% and Zone 5 starting at 100%, enter Zone 5 from 101%. Round any half percentages to whole numbers.

Steps follow TrainingPeaks' guides on [creating custom zones as an athlete](#) and [setting thresholds](#).

If you work with a coach. Coaches can build a Custom Zones template once and apply it to each Premium athlete through the athlete's gear icon and the Choose Method dropdown. It cannot be applied in bulk. If you drop from Premium to Basic, you and your coach lose access to those templates. See [Custom Zones](#).

Because Zones 1 to 4 shift with your LT1 percentage while Zones 5 to 7 stay fixed multiples of LT2, athletes in different categories need different run pace and power templates. Check which category you are in before you apply one.

Free plan athletes: set a threshold and use the Friel method

TrainingPeaks lists Custom Zones as a Premium feature, so on a free Basic account you enter a threshold and let a built-in method calculate the zones. Pick the Joe Friel method, which uses the same 7-zone shape as your calculator (Zones 1 to 4, then 5a, 5b, 5c).

On the web

1. Log in, click your name, and choose **Settings**, then **Zones**.
2. Choose **Heart Rate**, **Power**, or **Speed/Pace**.
3. Under **Add Activity**, add the sport. Set each sport you train rather than only the default.
4. Enter your threshold.
5. Under **Auto Calculation**, choose **Threshold**, then choose **Joe Friel** as the method.
6. Apply and save.

On the mobile app

1. Open **More** (iPhone) or the menu button (Android), then **Settings**, then **Zones**.
2. Choose the type, tap **Edit**, and enter your new threshold.

3. Choose **Calculate New Zones**.

The app calculates from the last method you used on the web, so choose Friel on the web first.

One trade-off to know about: the Friel method calculates every zone as a percentage of your threshold, so its Zone 1 to 4 boundaries may not line up exactly with your calculator, which anchors them to LT1 and LT2. Treat your calculator zones as the prescription and TrainingPeaks as the place you track time in zone.

If your Zones screen shows custom editing on a Basic account, you can follow the Premium steps above, but TrainingPeaks documents it as a Premium feature, so confirm in your own account.

Sources: TrainingPeaks' [metrics primer](#), [mobile setup help](#), and [coach pricing page](#).

Keeping your zones current

Zones are only as good as the thresholds behind them. Retest every 3 to 6 months, and sooner after a major shift in training focus or if your threshold cues change.

TrainingPeaks can alert you when your data suggests a new threshold. Go to **Settings**, then **Zones**, then **Notifications**, and tick **Notify me of threshold changes**. You can also tick **automatically apply suggested threshold changes**, though many athletes prefer to review each change first.

TrainingPeaks suggests an increase in these cases:

Sport	Threshold	Suggested when
Bike	Power	95% of your average peak 20 minute power is above your set threshold
Run	Pace	Your peak 45 minute average pace is faster than your set threshold
Bike and run	Heart rate	Your peak 60 minute heart rate, or 95% of your peak 20 minute heart rate, is above your set threshold

When you update a threshold, choose **Calculate New Zones** rather than **Use Threshold Only**, which is what TrainingPeaks recommends. If you use custom zone ranges, recheck them after any threshold change. Details are in TrainingPeaks' [threshold notification help](#).

Troubleshooting and coach notes

- **Metrics look wrong.** Check that a threshold is set for every sport you upload. Without one, TrainingPeaks uses the default threshold.
- **Zones do not show on a workout.** You probably set only the default zones. Add each sport under **Add Activity** and set its zones there.
- **Zone ranges will not save.** Zones are probably overlapping. Start each zone at the next whole number after the one before it.
- **No custom zone option.** You are either in the mobile app, which cannot create custom zones, or on a Basic account. Use the web, or use the Friel method with your threshold.
- **Zones differ from the calculator.** Built-in methods calculate from a percentage of threshold. Premium custom zones are the only way to match the calculator exactly.
- **Threshold unknown.** Use the numbers from your zone calculator or latest test. TrainingPeaks also publishes help on estimating thresholds.

For coaches: apply custom zone templates to each Premium athlete individually, since bulk application is not available. Build separate run pace and power templates for each athlete category, because Zones 1 to 4 shift with the LT1 percentage. If an athlete moves from Premium to Basic, they lose access to your templates.